



Stealing the spotlight:

The 28-year-old all-rounder, Sumit Kumar, was one of the finds of this year's domestic 50-over competition. VIJAY SONEJI

season. Thirty-two years on, Haryana's leading run-scorer from that epochal Ranji Trophy campaign, Amarjit Kaypee, is in charge of the State team as head coach. The helmsman on the field, Ashok Menaria, had a moment of redemption after beating Rajasthan, his home State that he served for 15 years, before unceremoniously parting ways earlier in 2023, in the final in Rajkot.

For those on the prowl for a young potential IPL talent, there was 28-year-old all-rounder Sumit Kumar, whose late cameo with the bat and early salvo with the ball earned him the Player of the Match award in the final and the Player of the Series accolade. His 18 wickets and batting strike rate of over 150 in the tournament may have catapulted the Gurgaon-born cricketer high into the wish list of enthusiasts. But Kaypee wants Sumit to increase his pace before moving to the next level.

Rajasthan's Aniket Choudhary, the

tournament's joint-highest wicket-taker, was surprised to be clocking 140 kmph after dropping pace over the last few years. The 33-year-old left-arm quick highlighted the importance of telecasting or streaming domestic matches live when he said that he realised he had regained his speed only because there was an online stream available for the semifinal between Rajasthan and Karnataka.

Choudhary, tied with Varun Chakravarthy, Siddarth Kaul, and Harshal Patel's 19 wickets in the competition and the only uncapped player from the lot, was the most impressive.

Yuzvendra Chahal's 18 wickets in eight matches for Haryana also played a role in his comeback to India's ODI squad for the tour of South Africa. After there was no telecast of any group stage matches, only four knockout games, held at the Saurashtra Cricket Association Stadium, out of nine, saw live

coverage. Meanwhile, at the remote Sanosara Cricket Ground 'B', about 30 kilometres from the SCA Stadium, where the high-profile quarterfinal clash between Tamil Nadu and Mumbai was held, there was an air of incredulity. Set against the backdrop of unending fields and wilderness, the sight of Dinesh Karthik and Ajinkya Rahane in half-built and hastily whitewashed dressing rooms struck quite a discordant note.

While Karthik and Rahane are past their prime, Rajasthan skipper Deepak Hooda made a strong case for a recall with a situation-defying 180 against Karnataka's vaunted pace attack in the semifinal.

With 480 runs, the third most in the tournament, and a strike rate over 100 at No. 4, Hooda proved yet again that he is a different batter higher up the order.

A few rungs below Hooda, Shashank Singh of Chhattisgarh, who scored 450 runs in the tournament, set a unique record against Manipur